SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #99 · MARRIAGE, SEX & FAMILY

“If my children turn away from God, I failed as a parent.”

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Where it often comes from

Reading Proverbs 22:6 as a guarantee. Comments from others that blame parents. Regret over mistakes you made while raising your children. Grief over a child who has walked away from faith. Comparing your family with others whose children seem faithful.

What Scripture teaches

Parents matter, and we are called to raise children in the Lord. But each person makes their own choices. Through Isaiah, God Himself said, “I have raised children and brought them up, but they have rebelled against Me.” God is the perfect Parent, and His children still rebelled. In Jesus’ story, the prodigal son left a loving father. Proverbs describes wisdom, not a guarantee. God is still at work in your children, and He welcomes prodigals home.

> *“Listen, O heavens, and give ear, O earth, for the LORD has spoken: ‘I have raised children and brought them up, but they have rebelled against Me.’”* **(Isaiah 1:2)**.

Also see

> “The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him” **(Ezekiel 18:20)**.

> “So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him” **(Luke 15:20)**.

> “I planted the seed and Apollos watered it, but God made it grow. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God, who makes things grow” **(1 Corinthians 3:6–7)**.

> “Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” **(Lamentations 3:22–23)**.

Common self-statements

- It’s my fault my child left the faith.
- If I had been a better parent, they’d still believe.
- Proverbs 22:6 proves I failed.
- Everyone at church blames me.
- God is disappointed in my parenting.
- There’s no hope for my child.

Common logical errors

- **Personalization:** Taking full responsibility for another person’s choices.
- **Reading proverbs as promises:** Treating a general principle as a guarantee.
- **Hindsight bias:** Judging your past parenting by what you know now.

- **Fortune telling:** Concluding your child will never return.

Challenging questions

- Did God's own children rebel against Him?
- Was the prodigal's father a bad parent?
- Is Proverbs 22:6 a promise or a general principle?
- Does my child have their own choices before God?
- What can I still do: pray, love, and stay connected?
- Is God finished working in my child's life?
- What mistakes can I bring to God and then release?

Truth summary

> If my children turn away from God, it does not automatically mean I failed. Even God's children rebelled against Him. My children make their own choices. I can confess my mistakes, keep loving and praying for them, and trust that God is still at work. He welcomes prodigals home.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Children
- Adolescent Rebellion
- Guilt/Shame
- Prayer, Answers to

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Parenting
- Adolescent Rebellion
- Backsliding

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If my children turn away from God, I failed as a parent"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If my children turn away from God, I failed as a parent." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did God's own children rebel?
- ☐ Was the prodigal's father a bad parent?
- ☐ Is Proverbs 22:6 a promise or principle?
- ☐ Does my child have their own choices?
- ☐ What can I still do?
- ☐ Is God finished with my child?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Even God's children rebelled against Him.
- ☐ My children make their own choices.
- ☐ I can confess my mistakes and release guilt.
- ☐ I can keep loving and praying for my children.
- ☐ God is still at work in my children's lives.
- ☐ God welcomes prodigals home.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Isaiah 1:2**
  "Listen, O heavens, and give ear, O earth, for the LORD has spoken: 'I have raised children and brought them up, but they have rebelled against Me.'"
- [ ] **Ezekiel 18:20**
  "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."
- [ ] **Luke 15:20**
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."
- [ ] **1 Corinthians 3:6–7**
  "I planted the seed and Apollos watered it, but God made it grow. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God, who makes things grow."
- [ ] **Lamentations 3:22–23**
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Prayer for my children:** Each day, pray for each child by name and write one hope I have for them.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Lamentations 3:22–23 becomes: "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD, **Sarah** and **her** children are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Parenting" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Read Luke 15:11–32,** and write how the father responded to his son leaving and returning.
- ☐ **Write a list of mistakes you regret,** confess them to God, and write "Forgiven" beside each.
- ☐ **Reach out to your child this week** with love, without pressure about faith.
- ☐ **Join with other parents** to pray for your children.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If my children turn away from God, I failed as a parent": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	I prayed for my children by name
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If my children turn away from God, I failed as a parent.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You know how much I love my children. Help me reject the lie that I failed because they have turned away from You. Forgive my mistakes, help me keep loving them, and draw them back to Yourself. I trust them to Your care. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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